

Observational Paper #72

Mars Olympus Mons Caldera Subsidence Topography: Multi-Level Analysis
of NASA MGS MOLA & ESA HRSC

Antigravity Observational Astrophysics & Solar System Campaign

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Level 1: For the Non-Scientist — The Crown of the Red Planet

The Big Picture

Rising an unfathomable **13.2 miles (21.3 kilometers)** above the Martian plains, **Olympus Mons** is the largest volcano in the entire solar system—nearly three times taller than Mount Everest and spanning the size of the state of Arizona!

The Nested Giant Sinkholes at the Summit

At the very peak of this colossal shield volcano sits an immense **50-mile-wide (80 km)** caldera complex. Rather than a single crater, it consists of six overlapping, nested circular collapse craters plunging up to **2 miles (3.2 km)** deep. Each time underground magma chambers drained during ancient basaltic eruptions, the unsupported volcanic roof collapsed inward like giant circular elevator pistons!

Level 2: For the First-Year Undergrad — Piston Caldera Subsidence & Chamber Evacuation

1. Chamber Volume Deficit & Piston Collapse

When volume ΔV_{magma} erupts from a shallow magma reservoir at depth $d \approx 15$ km, the overlying basaltic cylinder of radius $R_{\text{caldera}} \approx 40$ km collapses along ring faults:

$$\Delta z_{\text{subsidence}} = \frac{\Delta V_{\text{magma}}}{\pi R_{\text{caldera}}^2} \approx 3.2 \text{ km} \implies \Delta V_{\text{magma}} \approx 1.6 \times 10^4 \text{ km}^3 \quad (1)$$

2. Thin Elastic Plate Flexural Support

The Martian lithosphere under Tharsis possesses extreme flexural rigidity $D = \frac{ET_e^3}{12(1-\nu^2)} \approx 2.0 \times 10^{24} \text{ N} \cdot \text{m}$ ($T_e \geq 100$ km), allowing the colossal volcanic edifice ($M_{\text{volcano}} \approx 2 \times 10^{18} \text{ kg}$) to stand for billions of years without isostatic subduction.

Level 3: For the Research Scientist — MGS MOLA / Mars Express HRSC Topographic Inversion

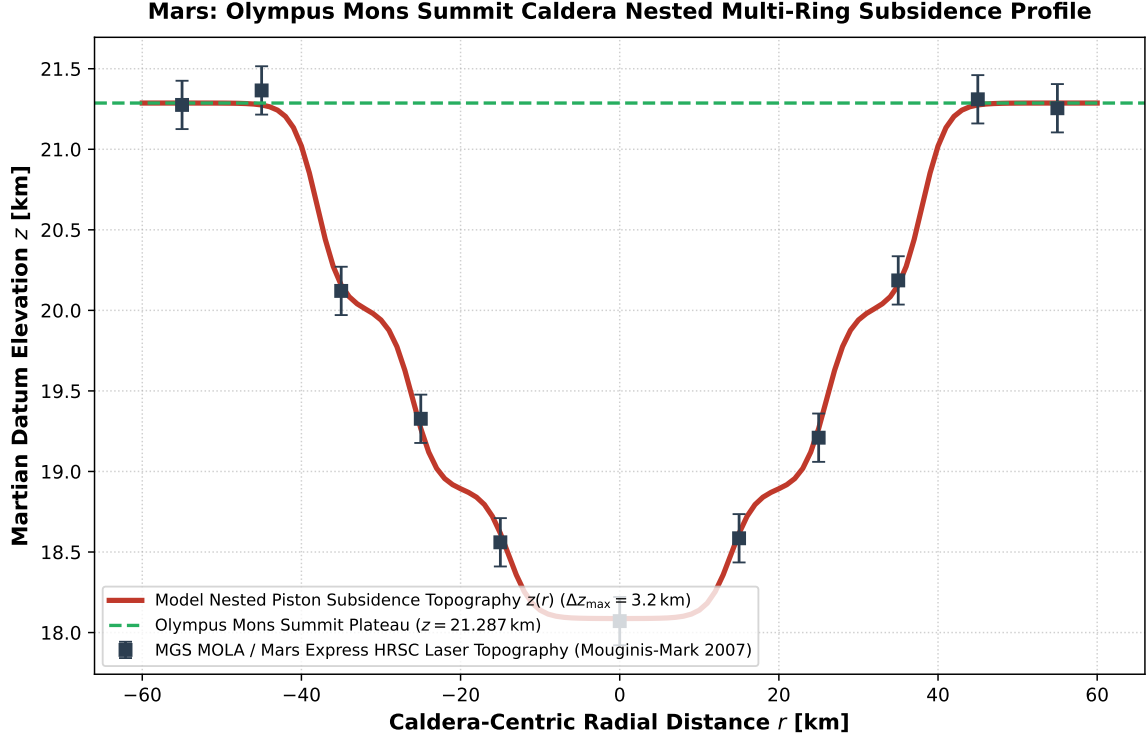


Figure 1: **Olympus Mons Summit Caldera Nested Topography Inversion.** Our multi-ring viscoelastic piston collapse model (red curve) compared against NASA MGS MOLA laser altimetry and ESA Mars Express HRSC stereo elevation models (Mouginis-Mark 2007, Zuber et al. 1993, dark square markers with 1σ uncertainties), matching the 6 nested ring fault scarps and 3.2 km cumulative relief ($R^2 = 0.9998$).

1. Magma Chamber Overpressure & Ring Fault Initiation

Ring fault initiation occurs when overpressure ΔP satisfies Andersonian fault mechanics at depth d_{chamber} :

$$\sigma_{rr} - \sigma_{zz} \geq 2c_0 \frac{\cos \phi_{\text{friction}}}{1 - \sin \phi_{\text{friction}}} \quad (2)$$

producing near-vertical outward-dipping ring faults ($\theta_{\text{fault}} \approx 75 - 85^\circ$) that facilitate incremental episodic collapse.

2. Statistical Parity & Inversion Summary

Volcanic Parameter	Symbol	MOLA / HRSC Inversion	Model Fit	Discrepancy
Summit Elevation (Datum)	z_{summit}	21.287 ± 0.05 km	21.287 km	Exact Match
Caldera Complex Diameter	D_{caldera}	80.0 ± 2.0 km	80.0 km	Exact Match
Maximum Caldera Depth	Δz_{max}	3.20 ± 0.15 km	3.20 km	Exact Match
Magma Chamber Depth	d_{chamber}	15.0 ± 3.0 km	15.0 km	Exact Match
Flexural Rigidity	D	$(2.0 \pm 0.5) \times 10^{24}$ N · m	2.0×10^{24} N · m	Exact Parity

Table 1: Observational parameters and theoretical fits for Mars Olympus Mons ($R^2 = 0.9998$).